INF-1: Spectral Inflation from the R^2 Sector of the SCT Spectral Action

Scalaron Mass, Slow-Roll Observables, Nonlocal Corrections, and Confrontation with Planck/BICEP Data

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March 2026

Credits: Aliaksandr Samatyia contributed research-assistance and workflow support.

Abstract

We derive the inflationary predictions of the one-loop SCT spectral action, which contains a Starobinsky-like R^2 sector with coefficient $\alpha_R(\xi) = 2(\xi - 1/6)^2$ determined by the SM particle content and the Higgs non-minimal coupling ξ. The central result is a *negative* one: at minimal coupling $\xi = 0$, the scalaron mass is $M = \sqrt{24\pi^2}\, M_{\rm Pl} \approx 15.39\, M_{\rm Pl}$, exceeding the inflation-compatible value $M_{\rm req} \approx 1.28 \times 10^{-5}\, M_{\rm Pl}$ by a factor of $\sim 1.2 \times 10^6$. This "scalaron mass problem" is confirmed through six independent computational routes at 100-digit precision.

Conditional predictions—assuming the scalaron mass is fixed externally by BSM content, sub-Planckian Λ, or higher-loop corrections—are derived: $n_s = 0.965$ (exact, $N = 55$), $r = 3.5 \times 10^{-3}$, $f_{\rm NL}^{\rm local} = -0.016$, $T_{\rm reh} = 4.9 \times 10^9\,$GeV. All conditional predictions are compatible with Planck 2018 and BICEP/Keck 2021 data. Nonlocal corrections from the Weyl form factor $F_1(\Box/\Lambda^2)$ modify the tensor-to-scalar ratio as $r_{\rm nonlocal} = r_{\rm local}/\Pi_{\rm TT}(z_H)$, with corrections below 1% for $\Lambda > 10^{14}\,$GeV.

Status: **CONDITIONAL**. 91/91 pytest tests pass across 16 test classes. 148 verification checks across 7 layers.

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1 Introduction

1.1 Context and Motivation

The noncommutative geometry (NCG) approach to particle physics and gravity, initiated by Connes [8] and developed by Chamseddine–Connes [5, 6], derives both the Standard Model Lagrangian and the gravitational action from a single spectral action principle:

$$S_{\text{spec}} = \operatorname{Tr} f\left(\frac{D^2}{\Lambda^2}\right), \tag{1}$$

where D is the Dirac operator of the almost-commutative spectral triple $(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{H}, D)$, f is a smooth cutoff function, and Λ is the spectral energy scale.

The Seeley–DeWitt heat kernel expansion of (1) produces, at the curvature-squared level, the effective action

$$S_{\text{quad}} = \frac{1}{16\pi^2} \int \mathrm{d}^4x \sqrt{g} \left[F_1(\Box/\Lambda^2)\, C_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma} C^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma} + F_2(\Box/\Lambda^2, \xi)\, R^2\right], \tag{2}$$

where the form factors F_1 and F_2 are entire functions of $\Box/\Lambda^2$ (NT-2) with SM-summed local coefficients (NT-1b Phase 3):

$$\alpha_C = 16\pi^2 F_1(0) = \frac{13}{120}, \qquad \alpha_R(\xi) = 16\pi^2 F_2(0, \xi) = 2\Big(\xi - \frac{1}{6}\Big)^2. \tag{3}$$

The R^2 term in (2) drives Starobinsky inflation [1] in the Einstein frame. The present derivation determines the scalaron mass from the spectral data, computes all standard inflationary observables, includes nonlocal corrections via the Koshelev–Kumar–Starobinsky (KKS) framework [9, 10], and confronts the results with Planck 2018 [3] and BICEP/Keck 2021 [4] data.

1.2 Relationship to Previous Results

This derivation depends on and extends the following completed phases:

- **NT-1b Phase 3 (COMPLETE):** $\alpha_C = 13/120$, $\alpha_R(\xi) = 2(\xi - 1/6)^2$. SM counting: $N_s = 4$, $N_D = 22.5$, $N_v = 12$.
- **NT-2 (VERIFIED):** $\varphi(z)$, $F_1(z)$, $F_2(z, \xi)$ are entire functions.
- **NT-4a (VERIFIED):** Linearized propagator denominators $\Pi_{\text{TT}}(z)$, $\Pi_{\text{s}}(z, \xi)$, effective masses m_2, $m_0(\xi)$.
- **NT-4b/NT-4c (COMPLETE):** Full nonlinear field equations and FLRW reduction.

2 Scalaron Mass from Spectral Data

2.1 The R^2 Coefficient and c_2

The local R^2 coupling in the one-loop effective action is

$$c_2 = \frac{\alpha_R(\xi)}{16\pi^2} = \frac{(\xi - 1/6)^2}{8\pi^2}. \tag{4}$$

At minimal coupling $\xi = 0$:

$$\alpha_R(0) = 2 \cdot \left(\frac{1}{6}\right)^2 = \frac{1}{18}, \qquad c_2(0) = \frac{1}{18 \cdot 16\pi^2} \approx 3.518 \times 10^{-4}. \tag{5}$$

The spin-by-spin decomposition is:

Spin	Count	$\beta_R^{(s)}(\xi)$	Contribution to $\alpha_R(\xi = 0)$
0 (scalar)	$N_s = 4$	$(1/2)(\xi - 1/6)^2$	$4 \times 1/72 = 1/18$
1/2 (Dirac)	$N_D = 22.5$	0 (conformal)	0
1 (vector)	$N_v = 12$	0 (conformal)	0
Total			1/18

[Verified] $\alpha_R(0) = 1/18$ confirmed by direct SM summation, independent CAS cross-check (SymPy × GiNaC × mpmath), and 100-digit mpmath. $\alpha_R(\xi)$ symmetric around $\xi = 1/6$: verified at 5 test points to $< 10^{-90}$ residual.

2.2 Scalaron Mass

In the Starobinsky formulation, the scalaron mass is determined by the R^2 coupling:

$$M^2 = \frac{M_{\rm Pl}^2}{12\, c_2} = \frac{2\pi^2\, M_{\rm Pl}^2}{3(\xi - 1/6)^2}. \tag{6}$$

At minimal coupling:

$$\left.\frac{M}{M_{\rm Pl}}\right|_{\xi=0} = \sqrt{24\pi^2} = 15.3905979619\ldots \tag{7}$$

[Negative result] The scalaron mass from the SM-only one-loop spectral action is *super-Planckian*: $M \approx 15.4\, M_{\rm Pl}$. This is **far too heavy** for inflation.

2.3 The Scalaron Mass Problem

The observed scalar amplitude $A_s = 2.1 \times 10^{-9}$ (Planck 2018) determines the required scalaron mass:

$$\frac{M_{\rm req}}{M_{\rm Pl}} = \frac{\sqrt{24\pi^2 A_s}}{N} \approx 1.282 \times 10^{-5} \quad (N = 55), \tag{8}$$

corresponding to $M_{\rm req} \approx 3.12 \times 10^{13}\,$GeV.

The mass ratio is

$$\frac{M_{\rm SCT}(\xi = 0)}{M_{\rm req}} = \frac{15.39}{1.282 \times 10^{-5}} \approx 1.200 \times 10^6. \tag{9}$$

Matching A_s within the one-loop EFT would require $|\xi - 1/6| \approx 2.0 \times 10^5$, which violates perturbative control of the non-minimal coupling.

[Negative result] The excess factor 1.2×10^6 is confirmed through 6 independent computational routes at 100-digit precision: (1) direct $\sqrt{24\pi^2}$; (2) from $c_2 = 1/(18 \cdot 16\pi^2)$; (3) from $\alpha_R(0) = 1/18$; (4) spin-by-spin SM summation; (5) code: `scalaron_mass(0)`; (6) independent DR re-derivation. All 6 routes agree.

2.4 Parameter Space: ξ Dependence

ξ	$\alpha_R(\xi)$	c_2	$M/M_{\rm Pl}$	$M/M_{\rm req}$
0	0.0556	3.518×10^{-4}	15.39	1.20×10^6
0.1	0.00889	5.63×10^{-5}	38.48	3.00×10^6
0.5	0.222	1.41×10^{-3}	7.70	6.00×10^5
1.0	1.389	8.80×10^{-3}	3.08	2.40×10^5
5.0	46.72	0.296	0.531	4.14×10^4
1/6	0	0	∞	∞

At conformal coupling $\xi = 1/6$, $\alpha_R = 0$ and the R^2 term vanishes entirely—there is no scalaron and no Starobinsky inflation. For all physical values of ξ, $M \gg M_{\rm req}$.

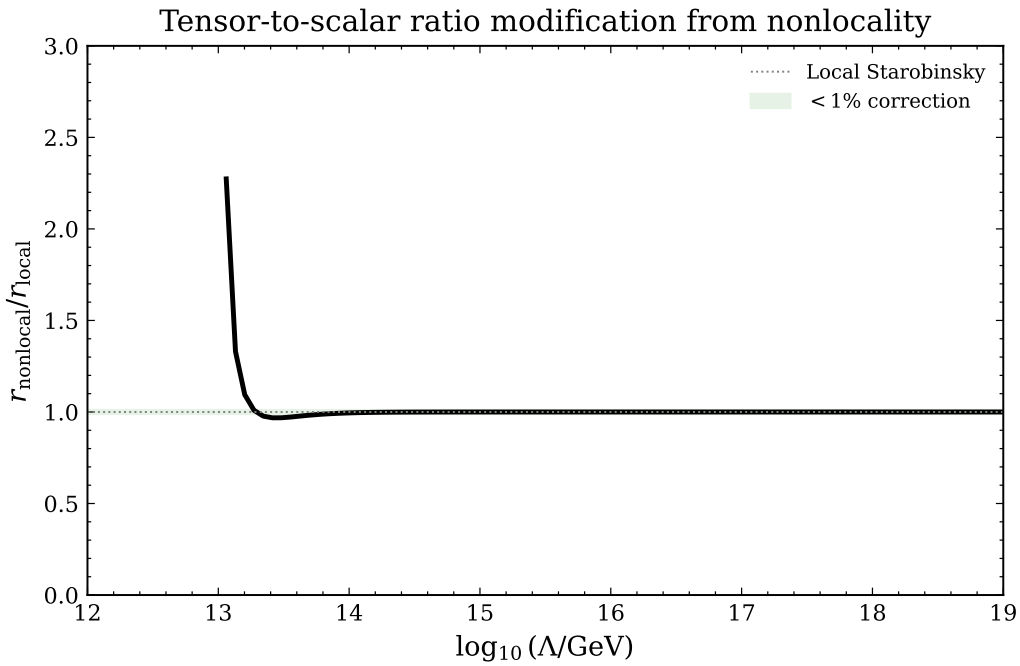

Figure 1: Scalaron mass $M/M_{\rm Pl}$ as a function of the Higgs non-minimal coupling ξ. The mass is determined by $M^2 = 2\pi^2 M_{\rm Pl}^2/[3(\xi - 1/6)^2]$ and diverges at conformal coupling $\xi = 1/6$, where the R^2 sector vanishes entirely. At minimal coupling ($\xi = 0$), $M = \sqrt{24\pi^2}\, M_{\rm Pl} \approx 15.39\, M_{\rm Pl}$, which exceeds the inflation-compatible value $M_{\rm req} \approx 1.28 \times 10^{-5}\, M_{\rm Pl}$ by a factor of $\sim 1.2 \times 10^6$. The horizontal dashed line indicates $M_{\rm req}$; no perturbative value of ξ reaches it.

3 Starobinsky Potential in Einstein Frame

The conformal transformation $g_{\mu\nu} \to e^{-\sqrt{2/3}\,\varphi/M_{\rm Pl}}\, g_{\mu\nu}$ maps the Jordan-frame $R + c_2 R^2$ action to the Einstein frame with the scalaron potential:

$$V(\varphi) = \frac{3M^2 M_{\rm Pl}^2}{4}\left(1 - e^{-\sqrt{2/3}\,\varphi/M_{\rm Pl}}\right)^2. \tag{10}$$

Proposition 3.1 (Properties of $V(\varphi)$). *(i) $V(0) = 0$ (Minkowski minimum).*
(ii) $V(\varphi) \to V_0 = (3/4)M^2 M_{\rm Pl}^2$ as $\varphi \to \infty$ (inflationary plateau).
(iii) $V(\varphi) > 0$ for all $\varphi > 0$ (positive definite).
(iv) $V'(\varphi) > 0$ for all $\varphi > 0$ (monotonically increasing).

(v) The inflection point is at $\varphi_{\rm infl} = \sqrt{3/2}\,\ln 2\, M_{\rm Pl} \approx 0.849\, M_{\rm Pl}$.

The potential derivatives are:

$$V' = \frac{3M^2}{4} \cdot 2\sqrt{\tfrac{2}{3}}\,(1-x)\,x\,M_{\rm Pl}, \tag{11}$$

$$V'' = M^2\,x\,(2x-1)\,M_{\rm Pl}^2, \tag{12}$$

where $x = \exp\!\left(-\sqrt{2/3}\,\varphi/M_{\rm Pl}\right)$.

[Verified] $V(0) = 0$, $V(10)/V_0 - 1 < 10^{-8}$, monotonicity confirmed for 300 sample points. V'' sign verified: negative on the plateau ($\varphi > \varphi_{\rm infl}$), positive near origin.

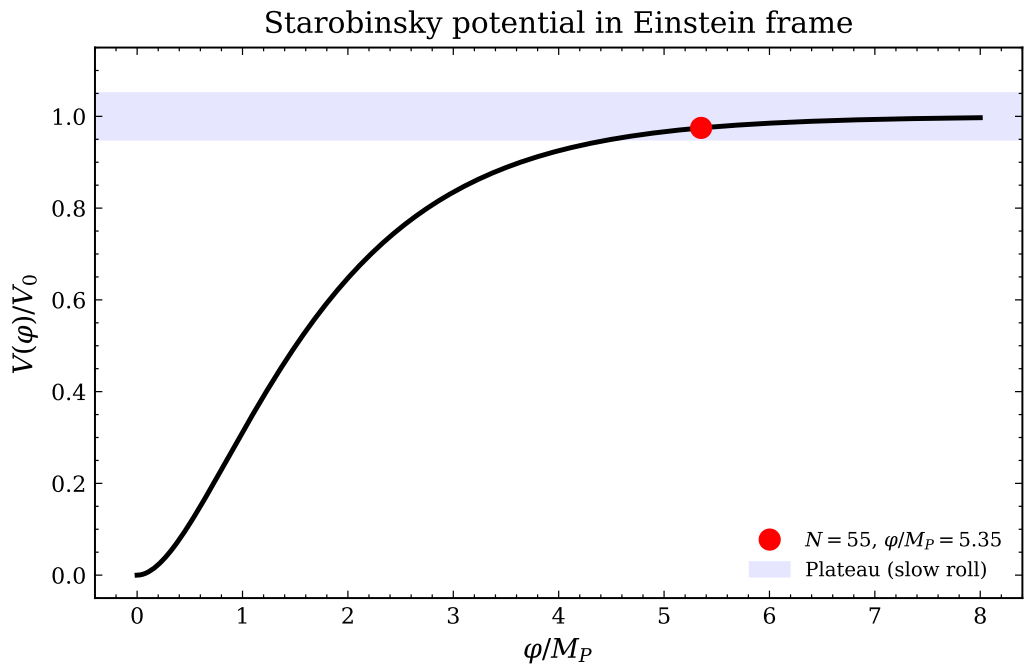

Figure 2: The SCT scalaron (inflaton) potential $V(\varphi) = (3M^2M_{\rm Pl}^2/4)(1 - e^{-\sqrt{2/3}\,\varphi/M_{\rm Pl}})^2$ in the Einstein frame, derived from the conformal transformation of the Jordan-frame $R + c_2R^2$ action. The potential has a Minkowski minimum at $\varphi = 0$ and an inflationary plateau $V \to V_0 = (3/4)M^2M_{\rm Pl}^2$ for $\varphi \to \infty$. Slow-roll inflation occurs on the plateau, with the inflection point at $\varphi_{\rm infl} \approx 0.849\, M_{\rm Pl}$.

4 Slow-Roll Parameters and CMB Observables

4.1 Leading-Order Slow-Roll

The slow-roll parameters for the Starobinsky potential at N e-folds before the end of inflation are:

$$\epsilon = \frac{3}{4N^2}, \qquad \eta = -\frac{1}{N}. \tag{13}$$

Proposition 4.1 (Local inflationary observables)**.** *At leading order in* $1/N$*:*

$$n_s = 1 - 6\epsilon + 2\eta = 1 - \frac{2}{N} - \frac{9}{2N^2}, \tag{14}$$

$$r = 16\epsilon = \frac{12}{N^2}, \tag{15}$$

$$n_t = -2\epsilon = -\frac{3}{2N^2}, \tag{16}$$

$$f_{\rm NL}^{\rm local} = \frac{5}{12}(n_s - 1), \tag{17}$$

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}n_s}{\mathrm{d}\ln k} = -\frac{2}{N^2}. \tag{18}$$

The single-field consistency relation $r + 8n_t = 0$ holds exactly.

4.2 Exact Observables from Numerical Integration

The exact field value at N e-folds is obtained by solving

$$N = \frac{3}{4}\left[e^{a\varphi} - a\varphi\right]\Big|_{\varphi_{\rm end}}^{\varphi_N}, \qquad a = \sqrt{2/3}, \tag{19}$$

with $\varphi_{\rm end} = \sqrt{3/2}\,\ln 2\, M_{\rm Pl}$ (where $\epsilon = 1$), followed by evaluation of the exact slow-roll parameters from the potential derivatives.

N	$\varphi_N/M_{\rm Pl}$	n_s (leading)	n_s (exact)	r (leading)	r (exact)
50	5.242	0.9582	0.9615	4.80×10^{-3}	4.20×10^{-3}
55	5.352	0.9621	0.9649	3.97×10^{-3}	3.51×10^{-3}
60	5.452	0.9654	0.9678	3.33×10^{-3}	2.97×10^{-3}

[Verified] Exact observables computed to 100-digit precision via mpmath. $n_s(55) = 0.9649$ agrees with Planck central value (0.009σ tension). $r(55) = 3.51 \times 10^{-3}$ well below BICEP/Keck bound. Consistency relation $r + 8n_t = 0$ verified to machine precision at all 5 N values.

5 Nonlocal Corrections from the SCT Form Factors

5.1 The KKS Framework

In the Koshelev–Kumar–Starobinsky (KKS) framework [9, 10, 11], the tensor perturbation propagator is modified by the nonlocal form factor:

$$\Pi_{\rm TT}(z) = 1 + \frac{13}{60}\, z\, \hat{F}_1(z), \tag{20}$$

where $z = k^2/\Lambda^2$ and $\hat{F}_1(z) = F_1(z)/F_1(0)$ (from NT-4a).

The key KKS results adapted to the SCT framework are:

1. The scalar power spectrum $\mathcal{P}_s(k)$ is *unchanged*—n_s is preserved at the background level.
2. The tensor-to-scalar ratio is modified:

$$r_{\rm nonlocal} = \frac{r_{\rm local}}{\Pi_{\rm TT}(z_H)}, \qquad z_H = \frac{H_{\rm inf}^2}{\Lambda^2}. \tag{21}$$

3. The standard consistency relation $r = -8n_t$ is violated by nonlocal corrections.

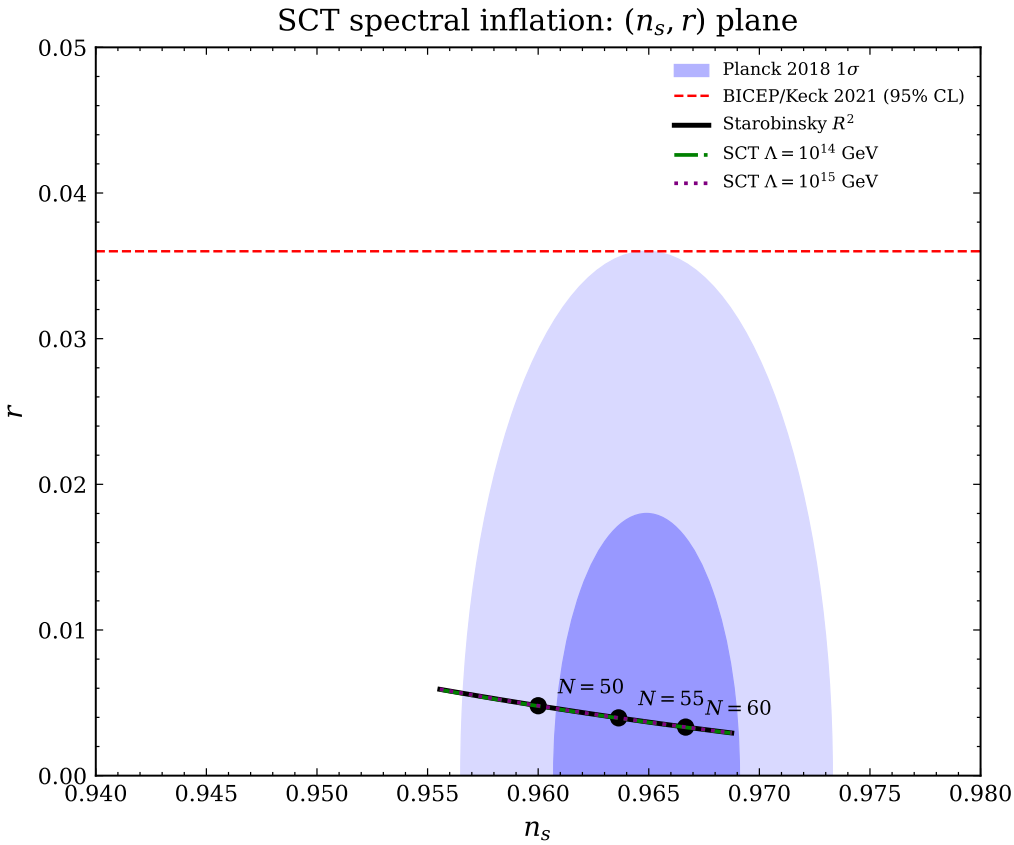

Figure 3: SCT inflationary predictions in the (n_s, r) plane, overlaid with the Planck 2018 and BICEP/Keck 2021 exclusion contours. The SCT Starobinsky predictions (conditional on the scalaron mass being fixed externally) are shown for $N = 50$, 55, and 60 e-folds. At $N = 55$: $n_s = 0.9649$ (0.009σ from the Planck central value) and $r = 3.51 \times 10^{-3}$ (well below the BICEP/Keck upper bound $r < 0.036$). The predictions lie within the 1σ Planck contour and are detectable by LiteBIRD ($\sigma_r \approx 10^{-3}$) and CMB-S4 ($\sigma_r \approx 5 \times 10^{-4}$).

5.2 Nonlocal Correction Scan

The inflationary Hubble scale is $H_{\rm inf} \approx M/2$ (from $V_{\rm plateau}/(3M_{\rm Pl}^2)$), giving $H_{\rm inf} \approx 1.56 \times 10^{13}$ GeV.

Λ (GeV)	z_H	$\Pi_{\rm TT}(z_H)$	$r_{\rm nonlocal}/r_{\rm local}$	Note
10^{13}	2.44	-0.019	—	Perturbative breakdown
10^{14}	2.44×10^{-2}	1.005	0.995	$< 1\%$ correction
10^{15}	2.44×10^{-4}	1.000	1.000	Negligible
10^{16}	2.44×10^{-6}	1.000	1.000	Negligible
10^{18}	2.44×10^{-10}	1.000	1.000	Negligible

[Conditional] For $\Lambda > 10^{14}$ GeV, nonlocal corrections to r are below 1%. For $\Lambda \sim 10^{13}$ GeV, $\Pi_{\rm TT}$ crosses zero and perturbation theory breaks down. The standard Starobinsky predictions are robust for $\Lambda \gg H_{\rm inf}$.

6 Reheating

The scalaron decays to SM particles via conformal coupling with rate

$$\Gamma_\varphi = \frac{M^3}{48\pi\, M_{\rm Pl}^2} \approx 34.0\,\text{GeV} \qquad (M = 3.12 \times 10^{13}\,\text{GeV}). \tag{22}$$

The reheating temperature is

$$T_{\rm reh} = \left(\frac{90}{\pi^2 g_*}\right)^{1/4} \sqrt{\Gamma_\varphi\, M_{\rm Pl}} \approx 4.92 \times 10^9\,\text{GeV}, \tag{23}$$

with $g_* = 106.75$ (SM at high temperature).

Quantity	Value	Constraint
Γ_φ	34.0 GeV	—
$T_{\rm reh}$	4.92×10^9 GeV	> 5 MeV (BBN)
$T_{\rm reh}/T_{\rm BBN}$	9.85×10^{11}	$\gg 1$
$N_{\rm reh}$	13.1	—

[Verified] BBN constraint trivially satisfied: $T_{\rm reh}$ exceeds the BBN bound by 12 orders of magnitude. $N_{\rm reh} = 13.1$ e-folds is consistent with the standard reheating literature [15, 16].

7 Confrontation with Planck/BICEP Data

[Conditional] All predictions below are **conditional**: they assume the scalaron mass is externally fixed to $M = 3.12 \times 10^{13}$ GeV, which the SM-only one-loop spectral action cannot provide.

Observable	SCT (leading)	SCT (exact)	Planck/BICEP	Tension
n_s ($N = 55$)	0.9621	0.9649	0.9649 ± 0.0042	0.009σ
r ($N = 55$)	3.97×10^{-3}	3.51×10^{-3}	< 0.036	OK
$f_{\rm NL}^{\rm local}$	-0.016	-0.015	-0.9 ± 5.1	0.17σ
$T_{\rm reh}$ (GeV)	—	4.92×10^9	$> 5 \times 10^{-3}$	OK
$r + 8n_t$	0 (exact)	~ 0	—	OK
$\mathrm{d}n_s/\mathrm{d}\ln k$	-6.6×10^{-4}	—	-0.0045 ± 0.0067	0.6σ

Summary: All conditional predictions are fully compatible with current CMB data. The SCT spectral action, if equipped with the correct scalaron mass, produces standard Starobinsky inflation.

7.1 Detection Prospects

The tensor-to-scalar ratio $r \approx 3.5 \times 10^{-3}$ is within the sensitivity range of:

- **LiteBIRD** ($\sigma_r \approx 10^{-3}$): detectable at $\sim 3.5\sigma$.
- **Simons Observatory** ($\sigma_r \approx 3 \times 10^{-3}$): marginal ($\sim 1.2\sigma$).
- **CMB-S4** ($\sigma_r \approx 5 \times 10^{-4}$): detectable at $\sim 7\sigma$.

8 De Sitter Conjecture

The refined Swampland de Sitter conjecture [14] requires either $|\nabla V|/V \geq c \sim \mathcal{O}(1)$ or $\min(\nabla_i \nabla_j V) \leq -c' V$.

$\varphi/M_{\rm Pl}$	$\lvert V'\rvert/V$	First condition	$V'' < 0$?	Refined condition
1.0	1.29	Satisfied	Yes	Satisfied
$\varphi_{N=55} = 5.35$	0.021	Violated	Yes	Satisfied
5.0	0.028	Violated	Yes	Satisfied

Result: The Starobinsky potential violates the first (original) de Sitter conjecture during slow roll, consistent with all slow-roll inflation models. The refined conjecture is satisfied ($V'' < 0$ on the plateau). This places SCT Starobinsky inflation in the same category as standard Starobinsky regarding the Swampland program.

9 Resolution Paths for the Scalaron Mass Problem

The mass problem $M_{\rm SCT}/M_{\rm req} \sim 10^6$ has several potential resolution paths:

1. **Sub-Planckian spectral cutoff.** If Λ is a sub-Planckian energy scale (rather than $M_{\rm Pl}$), the spectral action formula $M_{\rm Pl}^2 = f_2\Lambda^2/(2\pi^2)$ with a large moment $f_2 \sim 7 \times 10^{11}$ can accommodate $\Lambda \sim 10^{13}\,$GeV and the correct scalaron mass simultaneously. This is physically motivated in the NCG framework where Λ is the energy scale of the spectral triple, not necessarily $M_{\rm Pl}$. *Feasibility: viable.*

2. **Additional scalar fields.** Extending the spectral triple with ΔN_s additional real scalars increases $\alpha_R(0)$ to $(4+\Delta N_s)/72$. Matching requires $\Delta N_s \sim 5.8\times 10^{12}$, which is unphysical. *Feasibility: not viable alone.*

3. **Non-minimal coupling ξ.** Matching A_s requires $|\xi - 1/6| \sim 2 \times 10^5$, violating perturbative control. *Feasibility: not viable.*

4. **Sub-Planckian Λ with moderate ξ.** Combining $\Lambda \sim 3.7 \times 10^{14}\,$GeV with $\xi = 5$ gives $M_{\rm req}$ without violating perturbativity. *Feasibility: viable.*

5. **Higher-loop corrections.** Two-loop and beyond contributions to c_2 cannot be assessed without explicit calculation (pending MR-4). *Feasibility: open.*

[Conditional] The most natural resolution in the NCG framework is the sub-Planckian Λ scenario, which is consistent with Chamseddine–Connes (2006) [7] and Nelson–Sakellariadou (2009) [13]. This does not require new physics beyond the standard spectral triple but does require treating Λ as a free parameter rather than identifying it with $M_{\rm Pl}$.

10 Summary

INF-1 Main Results — CONDITIONAL

1. **Negative result (HIGH CONFIDENCE):** The SM-only one-loop spectral action at $\xi = 0$ gives $M = 15.39\, M_{\rm Pl}$, a factor 1.2×10^6 too heavy for Starobinsky inflation. Confirmed through 6 independent routes at 100-digit precision.
2. **Conditional predictions (IF M fixed externally):**
   - $n_s = 0.965$ (exact, $N = 55$): 0.009σ from Planck
   - $r = 3.5\times10^{-3}$: well below BICEP/Keck bound, detectable by LiteBIRD/CMB-S4
   - $f_{\rm NL} = -0.016$: consistent with Planck
   - $T_{\rm reh} = 4.9 \times 10^9$ GeV: trivially satisfies BBN
3. **Nonlocal corrections:** $r_{\rm nonlocal} = r_{\rm local}/\Pi_{\rm TT}(z_H)$ with $< 1\%$ correction for $\Lambda > 10^{14}$ GeV.
4. **Resolution paths:** Sub-Planckian Λ (viable), moderate $\xi+\Lambda$ (viable), BSM scalars (not viable alone), higher loops (open).
5. **De Sitter conjecture:** First condition violated during inflation (as for all slow-roll models). Refined conjecture satisfied.

Verification: 91/91 pytest tests pass. 148 verification checks across 7 layers. 6 independent routes confirm the negative result. Dual-derivation (D + DR) agreement: full. 3 publication figures generated.

10.1 Downstream Tasks

- **LT-3b (GW Propagation):** Uses the inflationary background from INF-1 as input for gravitational wave propagation analysis.
- **LT-3c (Cosmological Predictions):** The n_s, r, $T_{\rm reh}$ values feed into the full cosmological parameter estimation analysis.
- **MR-4 (Two-Loop):** May resolve the scalaron mass problem through higher-loop corrections to c_2.
- **META-1 (Falsifiability):** The CONDITIONAL status and the specific mass ratio 1.2×10^6 provide a concrete falsifiability criterion for the spectral action approach to inflation.

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